

WHAT YOU NEED TO KNOW: BELONGING

Background

Round 2 of The Extreme Heat and Community Resilience Program will fund Early and Advanced Infrastructure projects to mitigate the impacts of extreme heat. Project proposals for Round 2 must demonstrate how they advance the Extreme Heat Program Values of Harm Reduction, Collaborative Partnerships, Belonging, and Lasting Community Benefits.

Understanding Belonging as a Program Value

Projects that emphasize belonging ensure that infrastructure is designed with and for the people who use it, so that the community feels it belongs to them and, in turn, uses it and cares for it over the long term. Belonging comes from the process of genuinely engaging community members in shaping the design so that the finished infrastructure feels safe, welcoming, and reflective of the people it serves. Strong applications will describe the steps the applicant team will take to design the proposed infrastructure in response to the needs and desires expressed by the community.

What does Belonging look like in a project?

Belonging processes are the way in which your project team plans and designs for the users of the space and the larger community in which the project exists. When people help shape a space, they are far more likely to feel it belongs to them, and to use and care for it over the long term. Incorporating principles of community-based design or trauma-informed design into your community engagement efforts can help ensure that your heat mitigation solution aligns with the priorities and the needs of impacted communities and can increase participation from vulnerable groups. Community-based design relies on community input and expertise during the planning and development process with the goal of creating functional spaces that are appropriate for the community for which they are intended.¹ Trauma-informed design recognizes the emotional, social, and physical impacts of stress related to extreme heat and centers the emotional and psychological safety of users during the planning stages as well as the design and maintenance of the space.²

Results of belonging are the physical or social outputs developed by the community or with the community in mind. These elements create belonging because they come out of the community process. Incorporating belonging results into your infrastructure project might include public art like murals or sculptures; social engagement such as local music, dance, or community meals; or ecological placemaking and nature-based solutions like community gardens or native plantings.

¹Project for Public Spaces. *Eleven Principles for Creating Great Community Places*. Available at: <https://www.pps.org/article/11steps>.

²Rosenberg H, Errett NA, Eisenman DP. *Working with Disaster-Affected Communities to Envision Healthier Futures: A Trauma-Informed Approach to Post-Disaster Recovery Planning*. *Int J Environ Res Public Health*. 2022 Feb 2;19(3):1723. doi: 10.3390/ijerph19031723. PMID: 35162746; PMCID: PMC8835046.

Elements of Belonging

Inclusivity: Making an effort to get everyone to the table.

Use data and work with community leaders to identify heat vulnerable communities and better understand local and unique heat-related issues.

Ensure that identified heat vulnerable communities are represented and given power in the decision-making processes of the grant.

Pursue broad community support to cultivate a sense of place, safety, and trust.

Accessibility: Working to ensure open and equal access.

Ensure that marginalized voices have more say in future decision-making processes, even if it means going out of your way to bring community members to the table.

Develop a community-centered design process that meets the community's functional and access-related needs.

Connect with local groups like disability rights organizations, immigrant and/or ESL organizations, senior advocacy groups, and others to ensure that your project accounts for a wide variety of accessibility needs.

Creativity: Integrating the work of community creators and culture bearers.

Consider varying cultures within the project's community and how to bring them to the table to assess their unique needs and wants.

Engage creators, community artists, and cultural leaders to embed infrastructure into community through storytelling and cultural practices.

Co-create community-based strategies and solutions with members of the community that your project will serve.

Longevity: Planning for long-term community involvement.

Engage the community throughout the project to increase awareness of the project and process and increase long-term community buy-in.

Work with local community leaders to find ways in which the community and/or community organizations can participate in the project's care and maintenance after the end of the grant term.

Planning and Communication: Ensuring that your application reflects planned belonging activities.

Draft a timeline of specific activities planned to involve the community before, during, and after the active project phase.

Use your timeline to construct a clear and compelling narrative detailing your project's planned belonging initiatives before, during, and after project implementation. Be specific about planned activities and provide a clear explanation for how each activity will increase belonging and community investment.

Prompts to consider

Although the following questions are not included in the Full Application, considering them during application development can help you to understand and plan for Belonging throughout the application and planning processes.

- Is the proposed project developed as a response to expressed community needs or desires?
- How can we tailor the proposed project and project narrative to best reflect existing community desires and a commitment to long-term community buy-in?
- Who are the community members and stakeholders that should be included in designing the heat reduction infrastructure solution?
- What approaches to community engagement (surveys, public meetings, charrettes, etc.) will be most effective in ensuring heat vulnerable populations have meaningful influence over project design and implementation?
- What accessible design principles will be integrated in the overall project design to center the needs and experiences of potential beneficiaries?
- How are we ensuring that community recommendations are incorporated into the final infrastructure plans?
- In what ways will the proposed activities reflect the identity of the surrounding community (culture, history, community preferences)?
- What opportunities are there for residents to participate in the implementation of the project (e.g. events, public art installations, etc.)?
- What plans could be implemented to sustain a sense of belonging so that use of the constructed infrastructure lasts?
- How will relationships developed or strengthened during this project support future community-led heat resilience efforts?

Where and how to include Belonging in the Full Application

Belonging should be emphasized throughout both the Full Application and the project process. For a competitive application, integrate belonging in the following application areas:

- **Project overview narrative:** Ensure that this narrative explains how your project will be community-designed and driven.
- **Belonging questions:** This section is the best place to talk about your belonging activities in detail. Full Applications are considered strong when the narrative clearly explains how the applicant plans to engage the community before, during, and after the project in order to ensure that any implemented infrastructure is a direct response to expressed community needs and desires, rather than something constructed without broad community input. Describe the process by which you intend to create community "buy-in" and ownership towards the infrastructure that will last after the grant period.
- **Project workplan and budget:** In the project workplan and budget, detail your belonging design activities and outcomes under Task 3: Infrastructure Readiness. Connect your workplan and budget activities to the belonging activities you describe in the application narrative. For Early Infrastructure, a minimum of 4% of the total budget must go to belonging design. For Advanced Infrastructure, a minimum of 2% of the total budget must go to belonging design.

Additional resources

The following resources offer additional information and ideas for Belonging activities:

6 Tips for Inclusive Public Meetings

From the American Planning Association

[Click here!](#)

Learning Center

From the California Arts Council

[Click here!](#)

How the Arts Advance Society and the Economy

From California for the Arts

[Click here!](#)

Public Participation Toolkit

From the U.S. EPA

[Click here!](#)

The Spectrum of Community Ownership to Engagement

From Facilitating Power

[Click here!](#)

Tips for Equitable Digital Engagement

From the American Planning Association

[Click here!](#)

Project examples

Click on any of the following project titles to learn more about how Belonging shaped the project.



[Lexington, KY Sprayground](#)



[The Fargo Project](#)



[¡Sombra! The Celebration of Shade](#)



[NYC Rain Garden Stewardship Program](#)